NGO SUPPORT TOOLKIT · 03

Monitoring and Evaluation Starter Kit

Show what changed because of your work, not just what you did. A one-page theory of change, a results framework, indicator sheets and a simple learning rhythm for small teams.

Free to use and adapt **For** programme leads and M&E focal persons swkghana.org/support · October 2026

THREE WORDS TO GET RIGHT

- **Outputs** are what you deliver: 4 workshops, 120 people trained.
- **Outcomes** are what changes for people: 60% started saving.
- **Impact** is the long-term change you contribute to.

START SMALL

Pick three to five indicators you will actually use. A small set measured well beats a long list nobody has time to collect.

1 Your theory of change, on one page

Fill each box left to right. Then read it back as a sentence: *if* we do these activities, *then* these outputs follow, *so that* these outcomes happen, *contributing to* this impact.

PROBLEM	ACTIVITIES	OUTPUTS	OUTCOMES	IMPACT
What needs to change, and for whom?	What you will do.	What you will deliver, in numbers.	What will change for people.	The bigger change you contribute to.

Assumptions

What must be true for each step to lead to the next? For example: "trained farmers can get the seed they need." Write them down, then check them as you go.

2 Results framework

The core of your M&E plan. One row per result.

Level	Result	Indicator	Baseline	Target	Data source	Assumptions
Impact						
Outcome						
Outcome						
Output						
Output						
Output						

Baseline is where things stand before you start. Without it, you can't show change.

3 Indicator reference sheet

One sheet per indicator, so everyone measures it the same way, every time.

Indicator	
Definition	Exactly what counts, and what doesn't.
Unit	Number, percentage or score.
Break down by	Sex, age group, location, disability.
Data source and method	Survey, attendance sheet, interview, records.
How often	
Who collects it	
Baseline and target	

4 Collect data people can trust

- [ ] **Ask only what you will use.** Every question costs someone's time.
- [ ] **Test your survey** with five people before you send it to everyone.
- [ ] **Remove duplicates** before you count, for example by email or phone number.
- [ ] **Break results down** by sex, age and location to see who you are missing.
- [ ] **Get consent** and explain how the data will be used.
- [ ] **Store raw data securely** and share only totals, never names or contact details.
- [ ] **Write down your method,** so next year's numbers can be compared fairly.
- [ ] **Note what you can't measure,** and say so in your reports.

A consent statement you can adapt: "We are collecting this information to understand how our programme is working and to improve it. Taking part is voluntary, and you can stop at any time. We will keep your answers confidential, and we will only publish totals, never your name or contact details."

5 A learning rhythm for small teams

Every month
Update the numbers. Check activities against the plan. Flag problems early.

Every quarter
Review progress against targets with the team. Agree what to change.

Every year
Look at outcomes, ask participants what changed, and publish an impact report.

After every event or project phase, ask four questions

1. What did we plan to happen?
2. What actually happened?
3. Why was there a difference?
4. What will we keep, and what will we change next time?

6 Free tools that help

KoboToolbox
Free surveys and data collection, even offline. kobotoolbox.org

BetterEvaluation
Free guides to every evaluation method. betterevaluation.org

Ghana Statistical Service
Official data for baselines and context. statsghana.gov.gh

SDG indicators
Link your results to the global goals. unstats.un.org/sdgs

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